the boundaries of acceptable behaviour until their reputation was scoured by sandpaper. Where once they were praised as being assertive, they were criticized as being amoral.

Don't get me wrong. I'm not Mr Nice Guy 24/7. To put it into a context the Australians can understand, sometimes you have to have that bit of dingo about you. Paul Farbrace says there is something flinty, something slightly different, about myself, Rooty, Broady and Jimmy. We are not hard to manage, but we know our own minds, and are ready to fight our corner.

I try to be considerate in my dealings with the general public. I'm continually ready to offer my advice, if requested, to younger guys working through the challenges of their cricket career. But I'm far from perfect. I tend to be prickly when my standards are challenged and was often sharp when I felt we were training suboptimally.

I can be sarcastic. I'm not particularly proud of my impatience with a cameraman, trying to rig up a GoPro camera in the net when I returned to play for Essex after my knighthood. He took maybe thirty seconds, but I was waiting, as were the bowlers. 'Mate, hurry up,' I said, making things worse. 'You can't just have a net, can you these days, without being fucking filmed?'

He was just trying to do his job, but I eventually asked him to stop 'because I'm wasting my time here'. At one level, I was wrong in making him flustered and embarrassed. But on another, my training was being compromised. He was eating into the fifteen minutes I had scheduled to hit. In an ideal world, I would have apologized, and had what Farbrace calls 'one of those leave your beer and walk away moments'.

Swanny can be sharp and stubborn. He spent part of that evening at the Oval wandering about with a soft toy swan on his head, but there were weightier matters on his mind. In hindsight, he probably should have stuck with his original plan to retire there and then.

He had always dreamed of going out on an Ashes win, but the landscape was changed by the decision to stage back-to-back Ashes series to rationalize the cricket calendar so that the World Cup would not be a competing attraction. Players weren't consulted and were correctly concerned about intensified physical and mental strains. It should never happen again. That the plan was thrown out for 2019 tells you everything you need to know about the expedience of the modern cricket administrator.